



Tapping the Hydro Electric Potential

Sikkim has an immense potential for the most cheap, and non-polluting source of energy, namely, hydro power. Out of the 8000 MW potential of the state, a total of 5148 MW will be added by the end of the 11th Five Year Plan. Twenty-six new hydro power projects have been awarded to various power developers. The ambitious hydro power project in its entirety is already underway. By 2015, all 26 power projects of the state will be completed. From these, the Sikkim government will get 12 per cent free power. This is likely to meet the power shortfall in the state and will generate revenue as well. Furthermore, all job generated in the power projects are being given to local people depending on their qualifications.

It is a common concern of discerning citizens that the fragile environment of a place like Sikkim might be adversely impacted by power plants and hydro power projects. However, of all states of the country, Sikkim's ecological balance is among the most protected and many measures that have been taken by the state government to protect the environment will no doubt ensure a great degree of safety regarding any harmful effects of the ambitious hydro power projects undertaken by the Sikkim government. However, it is to be emphasised that all the hydro-power projects have been approved only after they were cleared by environmental experts, after they had made extensive scientific tests on the spots.

- » Sikkim has a potential of generating 8000 MW hydro-power.
- » Out of this, 5148 MW capacity will be added by the end of the 11th Five Year Plan
- » The state will earn over Rs. 1000 crores from proposed hydro-power projects.
- » All jobs generated thereby will be given to local people. Local contractors will also be favoured.
- » Most importantly, the state's stringent environment laws have ensured that the projects are 100 per cent eco-friendly.

Education for all

The State Government's belief that education is the catalyst that generates human resource and is the most potent weapon to fight poverty and ignorance has meant that educational expansion in Sikkim during the last decade has been phenomenal.

Its contribution towards socio-economic progress and steady improvement in the standard of living of the people is evident. National recognition of this achievement came when Sikkim was conferred with the Best Performing State award in the field of education in the State of the States conclave organized by the India Today group for two consecutive years [2004, 2005]

No effort has been spared to make Sikkim a hundred per cent literate state. Today, schools exist within walking distance, students can avail of free text books, uniform, rain coat, school bag, free mid-day meal and scholarships and stipends for the meritorious and under privileged children. Concrete school buildings have replaced the low cost school buildings. The literacy rate has increased from 56% in 1994 to 82% in 2006. In schools the teacher-student ratio is 1:18, which is the highest in the country.

The number of colleges has risen from five to eleven. Scholarships for outstanding students have been further enhanced, including the grant of Fellowships for Ph.D. and other research scholars. A Central Referral Hospital and Medical College in Tadong has been established, along with an Engineering College in Majhitar. Computer Training Centres, Polytechnic Institutes, besides a dozen colleges, Sanskrit Pathshalas and Colleges and a Centre of Computer and Communication Technology have been opened. A Central University is also being established in the state. The State Government is committed to make Sikkim a 100% literate state by 2015 and development of educational infrastructure is in tune with this policy.